

FREE RESOURCE · LEADERSHIP & COACHING

Difficult Conversations Framework

A 5-step framework for preparing and conducting difficult conversations at work — with preparation prompts, communication scripts, and de-escalation techniques for common scenarios.

[5-Step Framework](#)

[Communication Scripts](#)

[De-escalation Guide](#)

[Preparation Checklist](#)

5 steps	Scripts for each step	7 de-escalation scenarios	10-point prep checklist
---------	-----------------------	---------------------------	-------------------------

HOW TO USE THIS FRAMEWORK

Work through Steps 1–5 in order for your next difficult conversation. The scripts are starting points — adapt them to your own voice. The de-escalation techniques and preparation checklist are at the back. This framework works for performance conversations, conflict between colleagues, delivering unwelcome news, or any conversation where something important and uncomfortable needs to be said.

1

Prepare

Before the conversation — 20–30 minutes minimum

Most difficult conversations go wrong before a word is spoken. Poor preparation leads to unclear messages, emotional reactions, and unintended outcomes. Invest 20–30 minutes in preparation — the conversation will be shorter and more effective as a result.

CLARIFY YOUR PURPOSE

- ☐ **What specific behaviour or situation needs to change?** Write one sentence. If you cannot write it in one sentence, you are not yet clear enough to have the conversation.
- ☐ **What outcome do I want from this conversation?** Be specific — not 'I want things to improve' but 'I want us to agree a specific change by the end of this conversation.'
- ☐ **What does the other person need from this conversation?** They have a perspective, concerns, and interests too. What are they likely to be?
- ☐ **Is this the right conversation to have?** Is the issue mine to raise, or does it belong elsewhere? Have I contributed to the situation in any way?

CHECK YOUR OWN STATE

- ☐ **Am I approaching this with curiosity or judgment?** Curiosity leads to conversation. Judgment leads to a verdict. Which are you actually bringing?
- ☐ **Am I in a state to listen?** If you are angry, hurt, or anxious, the conversation should wait. Your emotional state will determine the tone more than your words will.
- ☐ **What assumptions am I making about the other person's intentions?** Most people do not intend to cause harm. Separate what you observed from the story you have told yourself about why.

PREPARATION PROMPT — USE BEFORE ANY DIFFICULT CONVERSATION

Write the answer to: 'The behaviour I observed was _____. The impact it had was _____. What I want to understand is _____. The outcome I am hoping for is _____.'

Complete this in writing before the conversation. It forces precision and reveals where your thinking is unclear.

SBI MODEL

The SBI model — Situation, Behaviour, Impact — is the most reliable structure for opening a difficult conversation. It separates what happened (observable) from what you think about it (interpretation). Use it to prepare your opening statement.

AVOID

Do not begin a difficult conversation when you are emotionally reactive. If you are angry or upset, wait until you can be curious rather than accusatory. The conversation you have in that state will create a second difficult conversation.

2

Set the Context

Opening — first 2–3 minutes

How you open a difficult conversation shapes everything that follows. The first 60 seconds determines whether the other person feels safe enough to be honest, or defensive enough to protect themselves. Your goal is to signal that this is a conversation, not a verdict.

CHOOSE THE RIGHT ENVIRONMENT

- ☐ **Private setting** — never give difficult feedback in front of others. Even if the behaviour was public, the conversation should be private.
- ☐ **Adequate time** — do not begin a difficult conversation five minutes before a meeting. Allow at least 30–45 minutes and block the calendar.
- ☐ **No interruptions** — phones away, door closed, do-not-disturb on. The other person needs to know this is important enough for your full attention.
- ☐ **Neutral territory if possible** — a meeting room rather than your office reduces the power imbalance slightly and signals that this is a conversation between peers, not a summoning.

OPENING — DIRECT AND NON-THREATENING

I'd like to talk about something that's been on my mind, and I want to make sure we have enough time to do it properly. What I want to share with you is specific — it's about [topic], not about you as a person. I'm hoping we can figure this out together.

The phrase 'not about you as a person' explicitly signals that you are separating behaviour from identity — this is critical for reducing defensiveness.

OPENING — WHEN THE CONVERSATION HAS BEEN AVOIDED FOR TOO LONG

I've been sitting on this for longer than I should have, and I want to acknowledge that. I should have raised it sooner. What I want to talk about is [topic], and I want us to have a real conversation about it — not just me telling you what I think.

Acknowledging that you delayed reduces the other person's sense that this has been building into something catastrophic.

POSITIVE INTENT

State your positive intent explicitly at the opening — not as a softener, but as a genuine signal. 'I'm raising this because I think you're capable of more than what I've been seeing, and I want to help you get there' is not flattery — it is framing.

AVOID

Do not open with 'How do you think things have been going?' when you already have a specific concern. This indirect approach is experienced as manipulative — the other person senses a trap. Be direct about the topic from the first moment.

3

Deliver the Message

Core of the conversation — clear, specific, then listen

The core of the conversation. Your job here is to describe what you observed and its impact — clearly, specifically, and without interpretation. Then stop talking and listen. Most people over-talk at this stage, repeat the same point in different words, or soften the message until it disappears.

THE SBI STRUCTURE IN PRACTICE

SITUATION — DESCRIBE WHEN AND WHERE

In last Tuesday's client meeting...

Specific time and place. Not 'in meetings generally' or 'often'. Specific.

BEHAVIOUR — DESCRIBE WHAT YOU OBSERVED, NOT WHAT YOU INFERRED

...I noticed you interrupted the client twice while they were describing the problem...

Observable and specific. Not 'you were dismissive' (interpretation) but 'you interrupted twice' (observation).

IMPACT — DESCRIBE THE EFFECT, INCLUDING ON YOU OR OTHERS

...and I could see from their expression that they felt cut off. Afterwards they didn't share the full detail we needed. I was concerned about the relationship with that client.

Impact can include how it affected the team, the work, the relationship, or you personally. All are legitimate.

AFTER YOU DELIVER THE MESSAGE

- ☐ **Stop talking.** Deliver the message, then pause. Silence is uncomfortable — resist the urge to fill it. The other person needs a moment to process.
- ☐ **Ask an open question, not a leading one.** 'I'd like to hear your perspective on this' — not 'Do you understand why that was a problem?'
- ☐ **Listen to understand, not to respond.** What they say next will contain important information. Do not use their speaking time to prepare your rebuttal.
- ☐ **Acknowledge what you hear before responding to it.** Disagreement does not require agreement — it requires evidence that you have actually heard what was said.

WHEN IT LANDS EARLY

If the other person responds well and acknowledges the issue quickly — do not keep pushing. Many difficult conversations are derailed by the person raising the issue continuing to make their point after it has already landed. Once it has landed, move to solutions.

AVOID

Avoid the word 'but' after any acknowledgment. 'I hear what you're saying, but...' erases everything before it. Use 'and' instead: 'I hear what you're saying, and I also want to make sure we address...'

4

Navigate the Response

During the conversation — stay curious

The other person's response will not always be what you hoped for. They may become defensive, deny the issue, deflect, go quiet, or become upset. Your ability to stay present and curious in this moment — rather than becoming defensive yourself — is the skill that determines whether the conversation moves forward or closes down.

COMMON RESPONSES AND HOW TO NAVIGATE THEM

- ☐ **They agree immediately.** Good — but probe gently. "I'm glad this makes sense to you. What do you think got us here?" Understanding the cause matters as much as the acknowledgment.
- ☐ **They become defensive.** Do not match defensiveness with defensiveness. Name it calmly: "I can see this has landed hard. That wasn't my intention — I'd like to hear what's coming up for you."
- ☐ **They deny it happened.** Return to the observable fact: "I understand we see this differently. What I observed specifically was [behaviour]. Can you help me understand what was happening from your side?"
- ☐ **They deflect — blame others or cite external factors.** Acknowledge the context: "Those pressures are real, and I want to hear more about them. I also need us to look at this specific situation."
- ☐ **They go silent.** Do not fill the silence immediately. Wait. Then: "I want to give you space to think. What's coming up for you?"
- ☐ **They become upset or emotional.** Pause the content of the conversation: "I can see this is hard. Let's take a moment." Emotions signal that something important is being touched — do not rush past them.

WHEN THEY CHALLENGE WHETHER YOUR PERCEPTION IS ACCURATE

You might be right that I don't have the full picture — that's actually one of the reasons I wanted to have this conversation rather than just form a view. Help me understand what I'm missing.

This disarms the 'you don't understand' response without abandoning your position.

WHEN THE CONVERSATION RISKS BECOMING CIRCULAR

I notice we're going over the same ground a few times. I don't think either of us is going to fully convince the other on this point. What I'd like to focus on is what we do from here. Can we try that?

Moving from past to future breaks circular arguments.

HELP ME UNDERSTAND

The most powerful phrase in a difficult conversation is 'help me understand'. It signals genuine curiosity, invites the other person to contribute, and avoids the dynamic where you hold the truth and they hold the excuses.

5

Close with Clarity

Ending — agreement, commitment, and care

A difficult conversation that does not end with clear agreement on what happens next has not finished — it has just paused. The close is where a conversation becomes a commitment. Do not leave without naming what was agreed, who owns it, and by when.

CLOSE CHECKLIST

- ☐ **Summarise what was agreed** — in your own words, cover: what the issue was, what change is expected, and what you will do differently (if anything).
- ☐ **Make the expected change specific and observable** — not 'communicate better' but 'send a summary email after every client meeting'. Vague agreements are not agreements.
- ☐ **Agree a review point** — name a specific time when you will check in on progress. This signals that the conversation matters and has not been forgotten.
- ☐ **Ask how they are** — a difficult conversation has a human cost. Before you close, check in with the person. 'How are you feeling about where we've landed?' is not weakness — it is leadership.
- ☐ **Thank them for the conversation** — genuinely. These conversations are difficult for both parties. Acknowledging that closes the interaction with respect.

CLOSING SUMMARY

Let me make sure I've captured what we've agreed. From your side, you're going to [specific action] by [date]. From my side, I'm going to [what you committed to]. We'll check in on [specific date]. Does that match what you heard?

Read it back. Do not assume agreement — confirm it.

WHEN THE CONVERSATION HAS BEEN DIFFICULT AND THE RELATIONSHIP NEEDS REPAIR

I know this wasn't an easy conversation, and I want you to know I value working with you — that's why I raised it rather than letting it build. I'm glad we could talk about it. Let's make sure we reconnect properly in the next day or two.

A repair signal is not a retraction. You can hold your position and invest in the relationship at the same time.

FOLLOW UP IN WRITING

Follow up with a brief written summary within 24 hours. Not a formal document — a short email that says:

'Following our conversation today, I wanted to confirm what we agreed...' Written agreements are significantly more likely to be acted on than verbal ones.

AVOID

Do not end the conversation by reopening the original issue. Once you have reached agreement, stop. Saying 'And just one more thing...' after a difficult conversation has been closed is one of the most damaging mistakes a leader can make — it signals that the agreement was not real.

De-escalation Techniques

When the conversation becomes heated — practical responses to specific triggers

De-escalation is not about defusing the other person's emotions — it is about staying regulated yourself while creating conditions where the conversation can continue. The techniques below are responses to specific situations, not scripts to read verbatim.

TRIGGER SITUATION

The other person raises their voice or becomes visibly angry

DE-ESCALATION RESPONSE

"I can see you feel strongly about this. I want to hear what you're saying — I find it easier to listen when we can both slow down a little. Can we try that?"

Why it works: Lowering your own voice while explicitly acknowledging their emotion does two things simultaneously: it models the regulation you are inviting and it signals that you are not threatened by their reaction.

TRIGGER SITUATION

The conversation escalates and both parties are becoming reactive

DE-ESCALATION RESPONSE

"I think we're both finding this hard right now, and I don't want us to say something we'll regret. Can we take ten minutes and come back to this? I'm not going anywhere — I want to finish this conversation, just when we're both a bit calmer."

Why it works: An explicit, mutual timeout — as opposed to storming out — signals that the pause is in service of the conversation, not an abandonment of it. Always give a time and commit to returning.

TRIGGER SITUATION

The other person makes the conversation personal or attacks you

DE-ESCALATION RESPONSE

"I notice the conversation has shifted from [the original topic] to something more personal. I'd like to come back to the original issue, because that's the one I think we can actually solve together."

Why it works: Naming the shift without emotional reaction removes the energy from the personal attack. Reacting to personal content escalates — redirecting to solvable problems de-escalates.

TRIGGER SITUATION

They say something like 'You always do this' or 'You never listen'

DE-ESCALATION RESPONSE

"I hear that this feels like a pattern to you, and I want to take that seriously. I'm not sure 'always' and 'never' are quite right, but the concern underneath those words matters to me. Can you tell me more about what you've been experiencing?"

Why it works: Fighting the 'always/never' language directly produces defensiveness. Acknowledging the concern underneath the exaggeration keeps the conversation moving.

TRIGGER SITUATION

The person becomes tearful or visibly distressed

DE-ESCALATION RESPONSE

"Let's take a moment. [Pause.] I can see this is really hard. That matters to me. Take whatever time you need — there's no rush."

Why it works: Continuing to deliver content while someone is distressed is counterproductive — they cannot process it. A full stop, genuine acknowledgment, and unhurried silence creates the conditions for the person to regulate and re-engage.

TRIGGER SITUATION

They threaten to involve HR or senior leadership

DE-ESCALATION RESPONSE

"That's absolutely your right, and I'd support you in doing that if you feel it's the right step. I'd also like us to try to resolve this between us first if we can, because I think we can. What would it take for you to feel comfortable doing that?"

Why it works: Becoming defensive about an HR threat escalates immediately. Acknowledging the right while expressing a preference for direct resolution keeps the door open and reduces the threat's power.

TRIGGER SITUATION

The conversation becomes completely stuck — neither party is moving

DE-ESCALATION RESPONSE

"I think we're stuck, and I want to be honest about that rather than pretend we're making progress we're not. What would it take from me for this conversation to move forward? I'll ask you to think about what it would take from you."

Why it works: Naming the stuckness as a shared problem — rather than a failure of one party — shifts the dynamic from adversarial to collaborative. It invites both people to take responsibility for the impasse.

THE MOST IMPORTANT DE-ESCALATION SKILL

Every technique above depends on one thing: your ability to stay regulated while the other person is not. You cannot de-escalate from inside your own reactivity. If you notice your heart rate rising, your jaw tightening, or your thinking narrowing — those are signals to slow down, not to push harder. Take a breath before you speak. The pause is the technique.

Preparation Checklist

Complete this before every difficult conversation

#	Preparation Task	Your Answer / Notes
1	What is the specific behaviour or situation I need to address?	
2	What is the impact it has had — on the work, the team, or me personally?	
3	What is the one outcome I am hoping for from this conversation?	
4	What is the other person's likely perspective? What do they care about?	
5	What am I assuming about their intentions? Is that assumption fair?	
6	Have I contributed to this situation in any way?	
7	Am I in the right emotional state to have this conversation now?	
8	What is my opening sentence — specific, behavioural, non-blaming?	
9	What is the most difficult thing they could say, and how will I respond?	
10	What does a good outcome look like — and what is the minimum I need to leave with?	

A NOTE ON TIMING

The most common reason difficult conversations are avoided is that the timing never feels right. It will not feel right. There is no perfect moment. The question is not whether to have the conversation — it is how long you are willing to let the cost of not having it accumulate. Every day a difficult conversation is delayed, the issue grows and the relationship carries more unspoken weight.